The other key player in the sting was a more mysterious individual with a rather intriguing name—Sohail Hindustani. Our reporting team had no clue as to who Sohail really was. Dressed in a T-shirt, he was, by all accounts, one of those Delhi wheeler-dealers who liked to show off his alleged connections with powerful people. It was Hindustani who was trying to organize the actual money transaction.

Our investigating team was first taken to Hotel Meridien where we were told that Congress leaders, including Ahmed Patel, would be found striking a deal. But when the MPs who had been miked up with a hidden camera reached the hotel, they did not meet anyone. All we had were dark shots of people moving in and out of the hotel lobby. Something seemed wrong. Kulkarni was livid. ‘Where are the Congress leaders you promised to get us?’ he asked Hindustani.

An increasingly desperate Hindustani started making more phone calls virtually offering the BJP MPs ‘for sale’. Late in the night, he finally got lucky. A Samajwadi Party MP, Reoti Raman Singh, landed up at the residence of the BJP MPs. Our team secretly filmed the conversations where the two sides talked of a potential money deal. Reoti Raman Singh asked the BJP MPs to meet his ‘leader’ the next morning to clinch the transaction. The presumption was that it was Amar Singh he was referring to. The MPs agreed. They went to Amar Singh’s house in the morning in a Zen car with tinted glasses but crucially refused to take the hidden camera or mikes in with them. ‘We don’t want to get caught and take any risk. Amar Singh is a dangerous guy,’ one of the MPs told Siddharth. We, however, did film the car entering the house.

But the real big breakthrough came an hour after the Amar Singh meeting. We had on camera someone called Sanjeev Saxena, ostensibly an aide of Amar Singh, meeting the MPs at their residence with a large bag of money. Kulkarni was delighted. ‘We have nailed this now, the sting is done!’ He even hugged our team and congratulated them. The cash was laid out on a table.

The tapes landed in the office around noon. Watching them, I knew we were onto potentially explosive stuff. The newsman in me was excited.